

Independent thinking traits

Independent thought goes hand-in-hand with independent behavior. Teens can show that they are ready for more independence not only in what they do, but in how they think and approach things:

Staying true to oneself and avoiding peer pressure shows strong self-belief and assertiveness.

Considering as many sides of a situation as possible lets a person decide what's right for them, without dismissing other perspectives.

Thinking creatively and using imagination allows teens to find ways of approaching a task that others haven't thought of.

Staying motivated and determined in the face of obstacles and setbacks encourages problem-solving and resilience.

GOOD TO KNOW

Thinking differently

Thinking independently allows a person to make informed decisions and to question the norm in order to consider new ways of doing things. By questioning rather than accepting, a person is able to deduce and logically come to their own conclusions, which may lead to fresh and innovative new ideas.



PARENT TIPS

Encouraging independence

- Give your teen space and autonomy to develop the skills of independent thought within a safe environment.
- Be available to offer help and advice when it is needed, but allow them to make their own decisions.
- Encourage your teen to consider the cause and effect of things that happen in their life, to help them consider different perspectives and encourage critical thinking.
- Show your teen how to admit and learn from their mistakes by discussing your own in front of them, by taking responsibility, and by explaining what you'll do differently in the future.
- Discuss issues and ideas with your teen. Give them space to voice their own opinions, but take care not to criticize them if you disagree. Instead, ask them to explain their thinking.
- Encourage your teen to ask questions.

Developing independent thought

Independent thought isn't simply a person asserting their point of view. It is coming to an informed conclusion following a sequence of thought processes that gather information, assess that information, consider external factors and past experiences—both failings and achievements. Following this critical thinking, a person can feel confident in their own thoughts, and build on them to learn and deduce independently.



◁ **Pulled in different directions**
Making sense of different and conflicting thoughts is one aspect of independent thought.